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CUET UG

History

# Medieval Society through Travellers Accounts

Themes in Indian History (Part II) · Theme 5 · Class 12

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Aligned to the latest official syllabus · Concept-first explanations

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## Syllabus Alignment

| Sub-topic | Official syllabus pointer (NTA History 314) | Skills the questions test |
|---|---|---|
| Al-Biruni & Kitab al-Hind | Al-Biruni's background (Khwarizm), Arabic text, 80 chapters, geometric structure, 3 barriers to understanding, critique of ritual pollution | Textual Indology, cross-cultural comparison, caste historiography |
| Ibn Battuta & The Rihla | Ibn Battuta's travels (Tangier), Muhammad bin Tughlaq's court, appointment as Qazi, descriptions of the unfamiliar (coconut and paan) | Ethnographic analysis, medieval urbanism, travel narrative critique |
| Postal & Communication Grid | State communication systems, horse post (**uluq**) vs foot post (**dawa**), speed multiplier, imperial surveillance and logistics | Institutional history, medieval statecraft, infrastructure analysis |
| François Bernier's Binary Lens | French physician in Mughal India (1656–1668), crown ownership of land thesis, critique of "camp towns", impact on Montesquieu and Marx | Comparative historiography, political theory, Eurocentric bias |
| Urban Economy, Slaves & Sati | Artisanal production in **karkhanas**, merchant guilds (**mahajans**, **nagarsheth**), female and male slavery, observations on widow burning (**Sati**) | Socio-economic history, gender and subaltern realities in medieval India |

**CUET Strategy & Exam Reality**

- **Core Exam Pointers:** CUET UG frequently tests exact details: the native cities of the travellers (Al-Biruni from **Khwarizm**, Ibn Battuta from **Tangier**, Bernier from **France**); the languages of their works (**Kitab al-Hind** in Arabic, **Rihla** in Arabic, Bernier's work in French); the technical postal terms (**Uluq** = horse post every 4 miles, **Dawa** = foot post with bell-rod, 3 stations per mile); and the intellectual theories derived from Bernier (**Oriental Despotism** by Montesquieu, **Asiatic Mode of Production** by Karl Marx).
- **Analytical Perspective:** Questions test the ability to recognize that foreign travellers brought pre-existing cultural frameworks that shaped what they noticed, what they praised, and what they misunderstood.

## 1. Al-Biruni and the Kitab al-Hind

**Al-Biruni** was born in 973 CE in **Khwarizm** (modern-day Uzbekistan), an important center of Islamic learning. He received the finest education available in his era, mastering Syriac, Arabic, Persian, and Hebrew. Although he did not know Greek, he was intimately familiar with the works of Plato and other Greek philosophers through Arabic translations.

- **Arrival in the Subcontinent:** In 1017 CE, when Sultan **Mahmud of Ghazni** invaded Khwarizm, he took several scholars and poets back to his capital, Ghazni. Al-Biruni arrived as a captive hostage, but gradually developed an abiding fascination for India.
- **Learning Sanskrit:** When the Punjab was annexed to the Ghaznavid Empire, Al-Biruni spent years in the company of Brahmana priests and scholars, learning Sanskrit and studying religious, philosophical, and scientific texts (Vedas, Puranas, Bhagavad Gita, and Patanjali's grammatical works).

## The Structure of the Kitab al-Hind

Al-Biruni's magnum opus, the **Kitab al-Hind**, was composed in simple, lucid **Arabic**. It is a voluminous work divided into **80 chapters** covering an encyclopedic range of subjects: religion, philosophy, festivals, astronomy, alchemy, manners and customs, weights and measures, iconography, laws, and metrology.

- **Geometric Methodology:** Al-Biruni adopted a distinctive, rigorous geometric approach across his chapters:
  1. Each chapter began with a clear, direct question.
  2. This was followed by a detailed cultural description based on Sanskrit textual traditions.
  3. The chapter concluded with a comparative analysis contrasting Indian practices with those of other civilizations (particularly ancient Greece and Persia).

## The Three Epistemological Barriers

Al-Biruni was acutely conscious of the cognitive and cultural hurdles that made understanding Indian society exceptionally difficult for an outsider:

1. **Linguistic Barrier:** Sanskrit was radically different from Arabic and Persian in grammar, phonetics, and vocabulary. Abstract philosophical terms in Sanskrit could not be easily translated into Arabic without loss of meaning.
2. **Religious Difference:** The profound divergence in religious beliefs and rituals made it difficult to interpret symbols and ceremonies without deep immersion.
3. **Insularity and Ethnocentrism:** The local population, especially the orthodox Brahmanas, displayed profound insularity, self-absorption, and intellectual aloofness, believing that no country other than theirs possessed true knowledge.

## Al-Biruni's Analysis of the Caste System

Al-Biruni sought to understand the social structure by cross-referencing Brahmanical texts with universal natural laws:




Figure 1: Figure 1: Comparative Matrix of Medieval Travellers: Al-Biruni, Ibn Battuta, and François Bernier across Origin, Methodology, and Societal Lens.

- **Rejection of Ritual Pollution:** Al-Biruni rejected the Brahmanical notion that certain low castes were permanently polluted by birth. He argued that the universal law of nature dictates that everything that becomes impure strives to regain its pristine condition:
  - The sun cleanses the polluted air.
  - Salt in the ocean prevents water from turning foul.
  - If nature did not possess this self-cleansing power, life on earth would be impossible. Consequently, he considered the concept of untouchable pollution to be a social aberration that violated natural law.
- **Comparative Classes:** To normalize the four varnas (Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra) for his Islamic readership, he pointed out that ancient Sasanian Persia had four distinct social orders: knights and princes; monks and fire-priests; physicians and astronomers; and peasants and artisans.
- **The Antyaja:** Al-Biruni noted the existence of eight categories of crafts-people (**Antyaja**) born outside the four varnas, including weavers, shoemakers, jugglers, basket-makers, and sailors. While subjected to social segregation, they were integrated into the urban economy by providing essential services.

## 2. Ibn Battuta's Rihla: An Inquisitive Ethnographer in 14th-Century India

**Ibn Battuta** was born in **Tangier** (Morocco) in 1304 CE into an aristocratic family respected for their expertise in Islamic legal scholarship (**Shari'a**). Unlike Al-Biruni, who relied primarily on written Sanskrit texts, Ibn Battuta was an empirical traveler who believed that firsthand travel and personal conversations provided far richer knowledge than books.

- **The Grand Journey:** Before arriving in India, he traveled across North Africa, West Asia, Mecca, the Syrian desert, the Swahili coast of East Africa, the Black Sea, and Constantinople.
- **Arrival in Delhi (1333 CE):** Drawn by the legendary generosity and patronage of Sultan **Muhammad bin Tughlaq**, Ibn Battuta traveled overland through Central Asia, crossed the Indus river in 1333 CE, and reached Delhi.
- **Career in Delhi:** Impressed by Ibn Battuta's legal erudition, the Sultan appointed him **Qazi** (judge) of Delhi, a post he held for nearly eight years. When he lost royal favor due to suspicion of associating with a dissident Sufi, he was imprisoned, but later restored to honor.
- **Mission to China (1342 CE):** In 1342 CE, the Sultan appointed him as his official ambassador to the Mongol court of the Yuan dynasty in China. Ibn Battuta traveled through Central India to Malabar, the Maldives (where he served as Qazi for eighteen months), Sri Lanka, Bengal, Assam, and Sumatra before reaching the Chinese port of Quanzhou (Zayton).
- **The Rihla:** Upon his eventual return home to Morocco in 1354 CE, the Sultan of Morocco ordered a scholar named **Ibn Juzayy** to record Ibn Battuta's travel memoirs, titled the **Rihla** ("Travels").

## Describing the Unfamiliar: Coconut and Paan

Ibn Battuta took great delight in describing exotic Indian flora that had no equivalent in the Mediterranean world:

- **The Coconut Palm:** He observed that the tree resembled a date palm, but bore a unique fruit. He likened the coconut to a human head: it had two eyes and a mouth on its husk, and its interior contained white kernel resembling human brain matter, from which sweet milk and nourishing oil were extracted. Its fibrous husk was spun into ropes used to sew seafaring planks together.
- **The Paan (Betel Leaf):** He noted that Indians cultivated the betel plant like a grapevine on trellises solely for its leaves. Devotees chewed the leaf with small crushed pieces of **areca nut** (**supari**) and slaked lime, which sweetened breath, aided digestion, and stained the lips red.

## Medieval Indian Cities: Delhi and Daulatabad

Ibn Battuta described Indian cities as bustling, populous, and intensely prosperous, sustained by a highly productive agricultural hinterland:

- **Delhi (Dehli):** A colossal metropolis covering an immense geographical area, surrounded by a massive fortified wall pierced by **28 monumental gates** (**darwaza**), the grandest being the **Budaun Darwaza**. Inside the ramparts were storerooms for grain, ammunition, and cavalry stables.
- **Daulatabad (Devagiri):** Located in Maharashtra, Daulatabad rivalled Delhi in size and splendor. Ibn Battuta was fascinated by **Tarababad**, a specialized marketplace for male and female musicians and dancers:
  - The market was decorated with carpets, swings, and fountains.
  - Female singers sat in curtained swings, singing before visiting Muslim and Hindu nobles, while shopkeepers conducted business to musical accompaniment.

# 3. The Postal Network and State Communication

How did the Delhi Sultanate govern a sprawling empire extending from the Indus to the Deccan? Ibn Battuta was astonished by the speed and sophistication of the state postal grid:

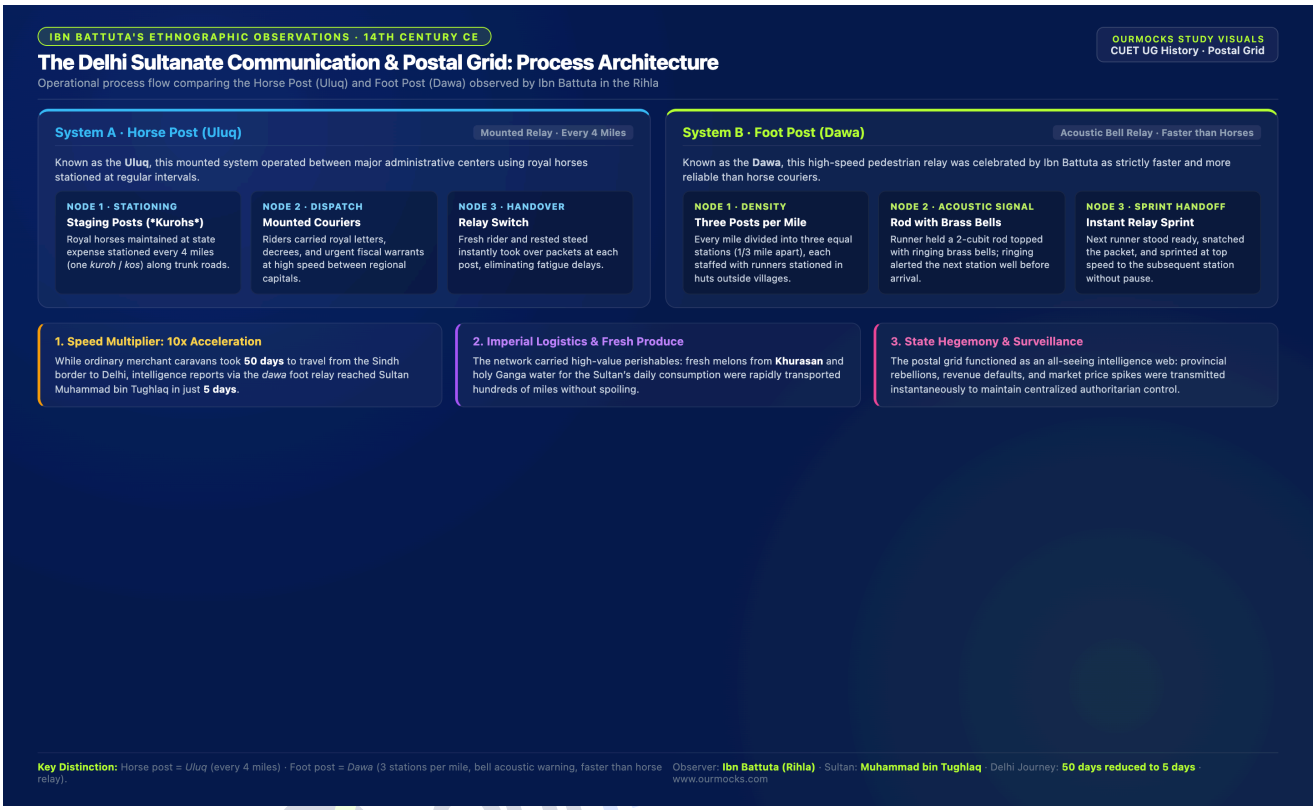



Figure 2: Figure 2: Operational Systems Flow of the Delhi Sultanate Postal Grid: The Horse Post (Uluq) and Acoustic Bell Foot Post (Dawa).

The communication system operated on two distinct tracks:

1. **The Horse Post (**Uluq**):** Run by royal horses stationed at regular intervals of four miles (**one kuroh / kos**) along major highways.
2. **The Foot Post (**Dawa**):** A pedestrian relay system with three stations per mile (**dawa** literally meant "one-third of a mile"). Outside every village stood a post staffed by swift runners:
   - Each runner carried a two-cubit-long rod topped with ringing brass bells.
   - When a runner sprinted from his station holding the dispatch in one hand and the bell-rod in the other, the ringing alerted the runner at the next station.
   - The next runner stood poised, grabbed the letters, and sprinted to the next post without pausing.

## Strategic and Logistics Functions

- **The 10x Speed Multiplier:** While a standard commercial merchant caravan required **50 days** to travel from Sindh to Delhi, intelligence reports carried by the **dawa** foot relay reached the Sultan in just **5 days**.
- **Fresh Perishables for the Court:** The postal system transported fresh fruits from **Khurasan** (Central Asia) and pitchers of sacred Ganga water across hundreds of miles for the Sultan's personal use.

- **Imperial Surveillance:** Provincial governors could not easily organize rebellions because secret intelligence (**barids**) reached the capital overnight, preserving centralized authoritarian stability.

## 4. François Bernier: A French Physician in the Mughal Empire

While Al-Biruni arrived in the 11th century and Ibn Battuta in the 14th century, **François Bernier** arrived in India in 1656 CE during the 17th century, when European maritime trading companies were actively expanding across Asia.

- **Background:** Bernier was a French physician, philosopher, and political theorist. He lived in India for twelve years (1656–1668 CE), closely associated with the Mughal court as personal physician to Prince **Dara Shukoh** (the eldest son of Emperor Shah Jahan) and later under the patronage of the intellectual Mughal noble **Danishmand Khan**.
- **His Text:** Bernier published his observations in France as **Travels in the Mogul Empire**, dedicating major sections to King **Louis XIV** of France.

### The Binary Lens: Comparing East and West

Unlike Al-Biruni's dispassionate Indology or Ibn Battuta's open ethnographic curiosity, Bernier wrote with an explicit ideological agenda: to contrast Mughal India unfavorably with Western Europe:

- **The Eurocentric Binary:** Bernier structured his descriptions as a sharp binary opposition:
  - **Western Europe:** Civilized, governed by the rule of law, protected private property, fostered an enterprising middle class, and prospered economically.
  - **Mughal India:** Tyrannical, backward, lacking private property, plagued by impoverished peasants, and ruled by a despotic autocrat surrounded by obsequious courtiers.

### The Crown Ownership of Land Fallacy

The central axis of Bernier's political analysis was his claim regarding the **absence of private property in land**:

- **Bernier's Thesis:** He asserted that the Mughal Emperor was the sole and absolute owner of all land in the empire. Crown ownership meant that land could not be inherited by private landholders or passing to their children.
- **Alleged Consequences:**
  - Because farmers were merely temporary tenants who could be dispossessed at will, they had no incentive to invest capital, dig irrigation canals, or improve soil fertility.
  - This resulted in ruinous agriculture, widespread peasant destitution, oppressive aristocrats, and the total absence of an improving "middle state" of independent landed proprietors.
  - India was depicted as a society composed solely of "beggars and barbarians" ruled by a "king of kings".

## Historiographical Reality vs. Bernier's Myth

Modern historians, drawing on contemporary Mughal revenue documents and the **Ain-i-Akbari**, have thoroughly refuted Bernier's thesis:

- **Mughal Reality:** The Mughal Emperor was not the sole owner of the land. The state claimed only a share of the agricultural produce (**mal** or land revenue), typically one-third to one-half. Peasants enjoyed hereditary occupancy rights (**zamindari** and **khud-kasht** rights) and could sell, gift, or bequeath land.
- **Global Legacy of the Fallacy:** Despite being historically inaccurate, Bernier's thesis deeply influenced Western political philosophy:
  - **Montesquieu:** Used Bernier's accounts to develop the concept of **Oriental Despotism**, arguing that Asian rulers possessed total arbitrary authority because all property belonged to the crown.
  - **Karl Marx:** Incorporated Bernier's ideas into his concept of the **Asiatic Mode of Production**, postulating that pre-colonial Asian societies remained stagnant because village communities were subjugated by a centralized state that monopolized land ownership and surplus extraction.

## "Camp Towns" and Urban Artisans

Bernier characterized Mughal cities as parasitic **"camp towns"**:

- **The Camp Town Concept:** He claimed that Mughal urban centers had no independent economic viability and were merely military encampments that expanded when the imperial court arrived and disintegrated when the court moved away.
- **Historical Inaccuracy:** 17th-century Mughal India possessed diverse thriving urban typologies: manufacturing hubs (Patna, Surat), pilgrimage cities (Varanasi, Kanchipuram), and coastal ports. Indian manufactures—particularly luxury muslins, silks, and metalwork—dominated world commerce.
- **Karkhanas:** Bernier himself paradoxically described the magnificent imperial workshops (**karkhanas**), where hundreds of skilled artisans produced gold brocades, fine embroidery, and damascened blades under state supervision.

# 5. Medieval Urban Centers, Trade, and Slaves




Figure 3: Figure 3: Comprehensive Topic Map & Architectural Framework of Medieval Society through Travellers' Accounts.

Travellers' narratives provide valuable windows into commercial networks, slavery, and gender relations that orthodox court chronicles often ignored.

## Merchant Communities and Urban Guilds

In trading cities, mercantile communities were organized into cohesive professional bodies:

- **Mahajans:** Merchant associations in western India led by an executive head known as the **Sheth**.
- **Nagarsheth:** In major commercial cities like Ahmedabad, the supreme head of all merchant mahajans was titled the **Nagarsheth** (chief merchant of the city), who represented civic interests before imperial governors.

## Slavery in Medieval India

Ibn Battuta's narrative offers extensive evidence regarding the ubiquity of slavery across the Delhi Sultanate:

- **Open Slave Markets:** Slaves were openly bought and sold in city markets like horses and cattle. Ibn Battuta himself purchased horses, camels, and slaves (both male and female) to offer as customary gifts when seeking an audience with Sultan Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- **Domestic Labor & Palanquin Bearers:** Female slaves were employed extensively for domestic chores, cooking, cleaning, and carrying royal ladies in palanquins (**dolas**).

- **Surveillance and Spycraft:** Female slaves were placed inside the houses of nobles by the Sultan to spy on their private conversations and report treasonous behavior to royal intelligence.
- **Musical Performers:** Highly talented female slaves were trained in vocal music and classical dance, performing at royal courts and festive assemblies.

### The Spectacle of Sati (Widow Immolation)

European and Islamic travellers were deeply shaken by the practice of **Sati** (the burning of widows on the funeral pyres of their deceased husbands):

- **Ibn Battuta's Horror:** Near the city of Amjhera (Malwa), Ibn Battuta witnessed a widow proceeding to the pyre accompanied by music and relatives. The horrific sight of her plunging into the raging flames caused him to swoon and collapse from his horse.
- **Bernier's Account:** In Lahore, Bernier witnessed the immolation of a young widow, barely twelve years old:
  - She was dragged screaming and weeping to the pyre by elderly women and Brahmanas.
  - Her limbs were tied to the wooden posts to prevent her from escaping the agonizing heat.
  - Bernier highlighted that while some older widows approached the fire voluntarily out of customary religious devotion, young girls were systematically coerced into self-destruction to protect family inheritance and honor.

## High-Yield CUET UG Exam MCQs

**Q1.** Al-Biruni, the author of the Kitab al-Hind, was originally born in 973 CE in which historic Central Asian city?

**(A)** Samarkand
**(B)** Khwarizm
**(C)** Bukhara
**(D)** Ghazni

**Q2.** In his Kitab al-Hind, which distinctive geometric methodology did Al-Biruni employ to structure almost every chapter?

**(A)** A chronological narrative followed by dynastic genealogical tables
**(B)** A beginning question, followed by a Sanskrit-based description, and concluding with cross-cultural comparisons
**(C)** A theological commentary on the Quran followed by critiques of local polytheism
**(D)** A dialogue between a student and teacher followed by mathematical theorems

**Q3.** Why did Al-Biruni refute the Brahmanical concept of ritual pollution associated with lower castes and outcastes?

**(A)** He believed caste was purely an economic division created by royal decree

**(B)** He argued that universal natural law dictates that everything impure strives to regain original purity, such as the sun cleansing air and salt purifying water

**(C)** He believed the Vedas explicitly mandated complete social equality among all humans

**(D)** He claimed that Buddhism had entirely eradicated caste distinctions across India

**Q4.** Which Moroccan traveler arrived in Delhi in 1333 CE, was appointed Qazi of Delhi by Sultan Muhammad bin Tughlaq, and dictated his memoirs titled the Rihla?

**(A)** Abdur Razzaq
**(B)** Duarte Barbosa
**(C)** Ibn Battuta
**(D)** Ibn Khaldun

**Q5.** In the Rihla, what two unfamiliar Indian plants did Ibn Battuta describe with intense fascination for his Mediterranean readers?

**(A)** Mango and Cardamom
**(B)** Coconut and Paan (Betel Leaf)
**(C)** Black Pepper and Sugarcane
**(D)** Banyan Tree and Lotus

**Q6.** According to Ibn Battuta, how was the pedestrian foot post (Dawa) organized under the Delhi Sultanate postal system?

**(A)** One runner every ten miles carrying a burning torch

**(B)** Three stations per mile, where runners carried a rod topped with ringing brass bells to alert the next runner

**(C)** Runners stationed exclusively along coastal waterways using signal flags

**(D)** Runners carrying trained carrier pigeons between provincial forts

**Q7.** How much time did an urgent dispatch from the Sindh border take to reach Sultan Muhammad bin Tughlaq in Delhi using the postal system, compared to a merchant caravan?

**(A)** 1 day compared to 10 days
**(B)** 5 days compared to 50 days
**(C)** 15 days compared to 100 days
**(D)** 20 days compared to 40 days

**Q8.** François Bernier, who spent twelve years in India (1656–1668 CE), served as a physician to which Mughal prince before entering the service of the noble Danishmand Khan?

**(A)** Prince Aurangzeb
**(B)** Prince Murad Bakhsh
**(C)** Prince Dara Shukoh
**(D)** Prince Shah Shuja

**Q9.** What was the central, flawed premise of François Bernier's socio-economic critique of the Mughal Empire in his Travels in the Mogul Empire?

**(A)** That the Mughal state had no standing army and relied solely on mercenaries
**(B)** That there was an absolute absence of private property in land, with the Emperor owning all land
**(C)** That Indian merchants refused to trade with foreign European maritime companies
**(D)** That manufacturing had entirely vanished from Indian urban centers

**Q10.** François Bernier's erroneous thesis regarding crown ownership of land in Mughal India directly influenced which two prominent European political philosophers?

**(A)** Voltaire and Jean-Jacques Rousseau
**(B)** Montesquieu (Oriental Despotism) and Karl Marx (Asiatic Mode of Production)
**(C)** John Locke and Thomas Hobbes
**(D)** Adam Smith and David Ricardo

**Q11.** What derogatory term did François Bernier use to describe Mughal manufacturing and administrative cities, implying that they depended entirely on the presence of the royal court?

**(A)** Garrison settlements
**(B)** Camp towns
**(C)** Temple enclaves
**(D)** Bazaar ports

**Q12.** In 17th-century commercial cities of western India, what was the collective head of the merchant associations (Mahajans) titled?

**(A)** Muqaddam
**(B)** Amil
**(C)** Nagarsheth
**(D)** Kotwal

**Q13.** Match List-I (Traveller) with List-II (Country of Origin):

- (a) Al-Biruni — (1) France
- (b) Ibn Battuta — (2) Italy
- (c) François Bernier — (3) Morocco (Tangier)
- (d) Niccolao Manucci — (4) Khwarizm (Uzbekistan)

**(A)** a-4, b-3, c-1, d-2
**(B)** a-3, b-4, c-1, d-2
**(C)** a-4, b-1, c-3, d-2
**(D)** a-2, b-3, c-1, d-4

**Q14.** According to Ibn Battuta's account, how did Sultan Muhammad bin Tughlaq utilize female slaves within his administrative statecraft?

**(A)** Exclusively to teach Sanskrit literature to foreign envoys
**(B)** To spy on the private conversations of nobles and report treason to the Sultan
**(C)** As field generals leading cavalry contingents into Deccan battles
**(D)** As agricultural managers supervising irrigation projects

**Q15.** Which specialized marketplace in Daulatabad was celebrated by Ibn Battuta for its musical performances, swings, and festive congregation of male and female singers?

**(A)** Chandni Chowk
**(B)** Tarababad
**(C)** Meena Bazaar
**(D)** Katra

## Solutions & Detailed Explanations

**Sol. Q1.** Al-Biruni was born in 973 CE in **Khwarizm** (situated in modern-day Uzbekistan). He was brought to Ghazni by Sultan Mahmud in 1017 CE.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q2.** Al-Biruni employed a geometric method: each chapter began with a question, was followed by a description based on Sanskrit traditions, and concluded with a comparison with other civilizations (ancient Greece and Persia).

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q3.** Al-Biruni asserted that nature purifies all things that become foul (the sun cleanses the air, salt keeps the sea fresh). He argued that permanent social pollution violated natural law.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q4.** Ibn Battuta, a native of **Tangier** in Morocco, arrived in Delhi in 1333 CE, was appointed **Qazi** by Muhammad bin Tughlaq, and dictated the **Rihla** upon his return home.

**Answer: ( C )**

**Sol. Q5.** Ibn Battuta described the **coconut** (comparing it to a human head with hair, eyes, and brain) and the **paan** (betel leaf chewed with areca nut and lime) as fascinating novelties.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q6.** The foot post (**dawa**) had three stations per mile. Runners carried a two-cubit-long rod fitted with brass bells; the ringing bells alerted the next runner to prepare for the baton relay handoff.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q7.** While merchant caravans took **50 days** to travel from Sindh to Delhi, the state foot post (**dawa**) delivered news and intelligence to the Sultan in just **5 days**.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q8.** François Bernier was the personal physician to Prince **Dara Shukoh**, the intellectual eldest son of Shah Jahan, before entering the service of Danishmand Khan.

**Answer: ( C )**

**Sol. Q9.** Bernier claimed that the Mughal Emperor was the sole owner of all agricultural land. He argued that the lack of private property prevented farmers from improving land, causing general destitution.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q10.** Bernier's crown land ownership thesis influenced **Montesquieu** to formulate the theory of **Oriental Despotism**, and **Karl Marx** to develop the concept of the **Asiatic Mode of Production**.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q11.** Bernier disparagingly termed Mughal urban centers **"camp towns"**, asserting that they were dependent entirely on the imperial court and military encampment for survival.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q12.** In western Indian mercantile towns, merchant associations (**mahajans**) were headed by a **Sheth**, and their collective city-wide leader was designated the **Nagarsheth**.

**Answer: ( C )**

**Sol. Q13.** Al-Biruni was from Khwarizm (a-4), Ibn Battuta from Tangier in Morocco (b-3), François Bernier from France (c-1), and Niccolao Manucci from Venice, Italy (d-2).

**Answer: ( A )**

**Sol. Q14.** Muhammad bin Tughlaq employed female slaves inside nobles' households as domestic intelligence operatives to detect rebellion and report private discussions.

**Answer: ( B )**

**Sol. Q15. Tarababad** in Daulatabad was a dedicated market for male and female singers and dancers, featuring swings, carpeted pavilions, and festive performances praised by Ibn Battuta.

**Answer: ( B )**

## Wrong-Answer Clinic: Common CUET Traps

| Common Mistake | Flawed Reasoning | Accurate Historical Fact |
|---|---|---|
| Confusing **Uluq** with **Dawa** | Assuming Uluq was the foot post and Dawa was the horse post. | **Uluq** was the horse post stationed every 4 miles; **Dawa** was the foot post with 3 stations per mile (literally 1/3 mile). |

| Common Mistake | Flawed Reasoning | Accurate Historical Fact |
|---|---|---|
| Believing Bernier was an unbiased observer | Treating Bernier's letters as objective primary fact. | Bernier had an explicit ideological agenda to contrast Europe favorably with Mughal India, exaggerating poverty to praise European private property. |
| Assuming Al-Biruni supported untouchability | Assuming all orthodox observers endorsed Brahmanical taboos. | Al-Biruni explicitly **condemned** the notion of permanent ritual pollution, arguing that it violated the universal self-cleansing laws of nature. |
| Thinking Ibn Battuta wrote the **Rihla** with his own hand | Assuming travel memoirs are always handwritten by the traveller. | Ibn Battuta dictated his oral memories to **Ibn Juzayy**, a court writer appointed by the Sultan of Morocco to compile the text. |
| Assuming Mughal cities were only military camps | Accepting Bernier's "camp towns" label uncritically. | Mughal cities were dynamic manufacturing and commercial hubs with global export trade (textiles, spices, metals) and organized merchant mahajans. |

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